understanding of the problem and the prediction about the impact of the intervention require research. Every intervention must flow from a theory of change, and our ability to theorize in India is quite limited.

Without deep roots in knowledge, the policy process degenerates into a contest of political and business special interests that harness the coercive power of the state to their own ends. Where we do not have high intellectualism, we get raw power play.

One way in which many countries ensure that state intervention works as applied research is by mandating that state agencies justify their intervention by providing the rationale in the form of an analysis of expected impact of the intervention. For example, some countries require analysis of benefits and costs to be done before any regulation or law is finalized, and usually this analysis is to be periodically reviewed to ensure that it still stands the test of evidence. Inputs into this analysis are given by myriad studies and reports that are available in public domain or are accessed or created by the agency looking to intervene in the economy.

The kind of research that serves as input for most of policymaking is social science research. Economists, sociologists, psychologists, political scientists, anthropologists, and others apply the methods of their respective discipline and sub-disciplines to present a picture of our world in a manner that is able to help us understand the general patterns, persistent trends, and notable exceptions in social phenomena.

In a process of iterative refinement, they help policymakers make sense of their world, and understand whether their perceptions, the petitions from stakeholders, the pressures from interest groups, and other sources of ideas are consistent with what the evidence is telling. In the modern world, the policy process consists of feedback loops from intervention, into the analysis of big data (either administrative data or private data sets), feeding back into refining the intervention.

Research and evidence is essential, not just in formulating policy responses, but also in making the decision to not act. On many problems, it requires sophisticated analysis to conclude that there is no substantial